posts all along the Indo-Tibetan border. Krishna Menon gave the order that all gaps still left unoccupied in the border area should be filled up. Even if sizeable forces were not available, he had said, at least a platoon of either the army or police or Assam Rifles should occupy these places. HQ XXXIII Corps, under the command of Lieutenant General Umrao Singh, protested against the order, prompting Kaul to personally fly down from Delhi in order to cajole them to get on with Operation Onkar. Accordingly, twenty-four new posts were set up in the Eastern Sector. The Chinese did not react to these posts, which were all south of the McMahon Ridge.

One of these posts was ‘Dhola’ that was to be set up on the Thagla. As per the ‘treaty map’ that he had, Dalvi suspected that the area was not a part of Indian territory. The brigade commander, along with the commanding officer of 1/9 GR, Lieutenant Colonel B.S. Ahluwalia, had in fact set off for Khenzemane to see the terrain for himself. His suspicion was endorsed by both Niranjan Prasad at the divisional and Umrao Singh at the corps level, the matter being referred to Bogey Sen in Eastern Command at Lucknow, who in turn further back-pedalled it to Army HQ.

The matter was referred to the DMO, Brigadier D. K. Palit, who decided to check with the Director of Military Survey who in turn said the existing maps of the area were ‘sketchy and inaccurate’. The file was sent to the Ministry of External Affairs who sent it back to MO with the noting: ‘We may permit the Army to extend the jurisdiction, if they have not already done so, up to the line suggested by them.’ This was good enough for the CGS, who was getting more and more impatient with what he considered to be stalling tactics on the part of the local commanders. Accordingly, Eastern Command, XXXIII Corps, 4 Infantry Division and finally 7 Brigade were told to go ahead and set up the post anyway.

In the Western Sector, the establishing of the first few posts in Ladakh under Operation Onkar initially seemed to confirm the assessment of the Intelligence Bureau that the Chinese would not like to escalate the situation beyond border incidents. At first, the Chinese simply pulled back, but once they realized what the Indians were up to, the PLA began to encircle the new posts. This resulted in a tit-for-tat reaction from the Indians, resulting in a bizarre tango with both sides being extremely careful to avoid opening fire in a fast escalating scenario.

In Army HQ, no one seemed to have done an appreciation of how the Chinese were viewing the developments. By this time, Kaul had complete